‘a body of Afghan plunderers who attacked all those who remained on the bank . . . Many in despair threw themselves into the river and were drowned.’[22] This was followed by the ascent of a steep pass, ‘where I found it requisite to hold tight on by the mane’, wrote Lady Sale, ‘lest the saddle and I should slip off together’. At the top they then got caught in the middle of an inter-tribal blood feud, but after the volleys they had just experienced in the Khord Kabul this seemed almost trivial in its violence, at least to Lady Sale: ‘A few jezails were fired; there was great talking and noise; and then it was over.’ Soon even the smallest pleasures seemed to the hostages wild extremes of luxury. ‘We enjoyed washing our faces very much,’ wrote Lady Sale one morning, and ‘had a grand breakfast of dal and radishes’.[23]

Once they arrived at the fortress of Akbar Khan’s father-in-law, however, conditions improved. In all the Afghan accounts, and in several of the Indian Muslim ones too, Akbar Khan’s kindness to his prisoners is regarded as exemplary and in the epic poems he is depicted as a paragon of chivalry, a sort of Afghan Saladin, which is still how he is remembered in Kabul today. Munshi Abdul Karim’s account is typical. ‘When Commander Akbar’s guests had somewhat recovered,’ he wrote,

> and were able once again to stand and move their frozen limbs, the Commander returned to the Fort to pay them a courtesy visit.
>
> The hostages all stood in line, trembling and fearful, to express their gratitude. Commander Akbar comforted them, and, showing great respect to General Elphinstone and the Minister’s widow, offered them sable-lined cloaks of cloth-of-gold, which he himself draped around their shoulders. He gave each of them a warm sheep-skin poshteen and with tears in his eyes, said ‘No-one can foretell, no-one can alter the decrees of fate and Divine will! The old men of Kabul in my army tell me that such extremes of snow and ice have not been seen in these parts in living memory. Have no fear – I will protect you and send you to the warmer clime of Laghman to rest and recover, until the sun enters the house of Pisces, the snows melt and the road to Hindustan will once again be open.’ Commander Akbar’s exemplary behaviour, fine manners, personal modesty, and solicitous care won the universal admiration of his guests, who swore lifelong gratitude. Once the hostage guests had reached Laghman, spacious apartments were set aside for the ladies, with serving girls in attendance. Food too was generously provided: grains and meat, the fat sheeps’ tails, chickens, eggs, as well as all kinds of dried and fresh fruits.[24]

What is perhaps more surprising is that while some British accounts do concentrate on the sufferings of the prisoners of war, many also commend Akbar for his care of them. Pottinger formally wrote to General Pollock to assure him ‘that in the Afghan fashion, we received every attention which prisoners could expect, and that any incivility we received was from the